

ANI



4



5

1. Coloured laser beams light up Ram ki Paidi

2. Sadhus being taken to the venue in motorised carts

3. Snack boxes with local winter foods

4. Sun-like orbs on lamp posts illuminate the Dharam Path

5. Little ghantis engraved with the consecration date

Superstar Amitabh Bachchan was there with son Abhishek, as were Rajinikanth and Chiranjeevi. Sports legends like Sachin Tendulkar and Saina Nehwal marked their presence too. All the tickets had QR codes and sections were well allocated.

The seats had thick Dunlop cushions encased in pristine white so that they would not be cold or hard to sit on. Hot chai from thermos flasks and cold bottles of water were served throughout the ceremony. Later, there were snack boxes with chips, a selection of dry fruits, revdi, makhanas and ramdana laddoos. A nod to India's local winter foods. The snack boxes even came with their own wet wipes!

Top of the Mantra Pop

While they waited, the guests were treated to mantras and bhajans sung live by some of the country's biggest singers—Sonu Nigam, Shankar Mahadevan and others. Little brass bells with the date of the consecration ceremony engraved on them were handed to all so that they could be part of the *aarti*. But the one thing that was truly magical was the hypnotic Ram chant by folk singer Malini Awasthi. It evoked tears, jubilation and dance among the audience.

The temple itself was bedecked with elaborate flower arrangements everywhere you looked—blue orchids fashioned like the elaborate plumage of our national bird, the peacock. 'Jai Shri Ram' written in flowers hanging from high facades. The darshan itself saw a bit of a crush. People lost their patience and sense of order as their enthusiasm got the better of them. The temple is too new to have protocols on how to manage the crowds and was perhaps reeling under the weight of its own popularity.

The evening saw laser displays with synchronised fountains and music. Remixed Ram bhajans on loudspeakers, performing troops bursting into song and dance...for a while, the city felt like one spontaneous street party. Ramayana episodes played out on a giant screen 65 ft in height and 200 ft in length made of cloth stretched across a huge truss on this promenade. Like a giant open-air theatre under the stars. The atmosphere in Ayodhya was not sober or peaceful, it was electric. An unleashed energy that was bouncing off the freshly made walls. It was as though the city was celebrating its revival. ■